46TH ANNIVERSARY

THE NEXT 100

DANCE

Best Foot Forward

ARUSHI MUDGAL, 35

Odissi dancer, Delhi

Arushi Mudgal dances because she loves it too much—with or without music. "I see rhythm around me all the time, be it the ticking of the clock or water dripping from the tap or the sound of a train running on the tracks. The natural movements fascinate me," she says. It's quite natural for Mudgal, who took her Odissi training under her aunt Guru Madhavi Mudgal, as she wakes up to an *alaap* or the sounds of *ghungroo* at the Gandharva Mahavidyalaya in Delhi where she stays. She has not only performed and choreographed dance in Odissi, but also collaborated with French percussionists and was even invited by celebrated choreographer Pina Bausch to Germany to perform at the Internationales Tanz Festival. She brings in old-world charm and the vibrancy of the new age. Her dance is eloquent, graceful and brings an intensity that's captivating. "I seek that abandon in my dance. What I like is the struggle in the journey of creating dance more than the final product," says Mudgal, who has co-authored *The Bud and the Blossom*, on the aesthetics of Odissi, with musicologist and academic Sushil Saxena. During the pandemic, she took to Instagram to showcase her movements in dance, which made her realise how engagement with art is so important to life. Awarded the Sangeet Natak Akademi Yuva Puraskar for her excellence, she has a huge legacy to carry on her shoulders—that of the Kelucharan Mohapatra *gharana*, but is confident of doing so. "Till death do we dance," she says, seeing the fragility of life in the time of the pandemic. ■

– S. Sahaya Ranjit

ET CETERA She has written a story for Gautham Menon's *Paava Kadhaigal*, a Netflix anthology on honour killings